Lesson 0.3: Claude Desktop tour

Claude Certified Associate – Foundations (CCAO-F) · Section 0: Start Here · Lesson 3 · 10:55

Description

A guided first tour of Claude Desktop for someone who has never used it. You meet the three places to work (Chat, Cowork and Code), the toolbox behind the plus button, the model picker, and the Settings pages that decide what Claude may do. Each of the seven main tools (Projects, Artifacts, Research, Memory, Skills, Connectors and code execution) gets one plain line and its place in the app. You also see where those facts come from: Anthropic's blog, the Help Center and the official exam guide. Then you run a real first chat. Sonnet 5.5 turns this course's real Module 1 lesson list into a five-day study plan, Haiku 4.5 shrinks it to a sticky note, and both answers get checked against the list. The lesson ends with one exam-style scenario, reasoned out loud.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this lesson you can:

1. Find your way around Claude Desktop: Chat, Cowork, Code and Settings.
2. Say in one line what each main tool does and where it lives.
3. Run your first chat, and switch models when the job changes.

Chapters

Time	Chapter
00:00	Preview and outcomes
00:32	Why it matters
01:16	The map
02:39	Straight from the source
03:26	Hands-on: your first tour
09:32	Exam angle
10:16	Recap and quick check

Your app may look different: the Chat | Cowork switch

On September 16, 2026, Anthropic announced that Claude Cowork and chat are merging into one Claude. The new experience is rolling out in stages, starting with Pro and Max plans on web, desktop and mobile, with more plans to follow. Accounts on the same plan get it at different times, and there is nothing to turn on. This lesson was recorded on 2026-10-03 on an account that did not have it yet, so the message box still shows the **Chat | Cowork** switch.

How to tell which one you have. The Help Center's own test: "If you're on a Pro or Max plan and your message box still shows "Chat" and "Cowork" options, you don't have it yet." If your switch is gone, you have the merged layout. There's no mode to pick: you just ask in any conversation, and Claude can take on the bigger, multi-step work Cowork used to do. Once an account has moved over, it can't switch back.

What stays and what moves (Help Center, "What happened to Claude Cowork?" and "What's in a new place"):

- Stays: "The model picker and the "Code" tab are where they were." Your chats, Cowork tasks, projects, connectors, skills, artifacts and files carry over. The + menu, Settings and Customize work as shown in the lesson.
- Moves: Cowork tasks now sit with your chats in **Recents**. There's no web search toggle, because Claude searches the web when it helps. **Research** is under + → Research, or you type `/deep-research`. Cowork's Global instructions become part of **Instructions for Claude** in Settings > General.

Sources: Anthropic blog, *Claude Cowork and chat are now one Claude* (September 16, 2026), https://claude.com/blog/cowork-is-now-claude, and Claude Help Center, *Claude Cowork and chat are one Claude*, https://support.claude.com/en/articles/16761823-claude-cowork-and-chat-are-one-claude (both checked 2026-10-03).

Key terms

- **Surface:** a place in Claude Desktop where you work: Chat, Cowork or Code.
- **Cowork:** handing Claude a bigger, multi-step job to finish while you do other things. Since September 16, 2026 it is merging into every conversation, account by account.
- **Model picker:** the menu next to the send button that chooses the model (Haiku, Sonnet or Opus) and its effort. A switch applies from the next reply.
- **Connector:** a link that lets Claude read from and act in your other apps, using your own permissions in each one.
- **Capability:** a switch in Settings → Capabilities for what Claude may do, like code execution and file creation.

The seven tools in one line each

Tool	What it does	Where it lives (both layouts)	Taught in
Projects	Workspaces with their own chats, files and instructions	Sidebar → Projects; + → Add to project	5.1
Artifacts	Things Claude makes that you'd put in front of someone (a document, a deck, a small tool), opening beside the chat	Beside the chat; sidebar → Artifacts; Settings → Capabilities	3.6

Tool	What it does	Where it lives (both layouts)	Taught in
Research	Many searches that build on each other, then one report with citations you can check, in minutes	+ → Research (merged layout: also `/deep-research`)	4.2
Memory	Carries context from your past chats into new ones. You can turn it off for one chat in the + menu before the first message	+ → Memory; Settings → Memory	1.4
Skills	Saved how-tos that Claude loads when a task needs one. They need code execution	+ → Skills; Settings → Customize → Skills	5.3
Connectors	Links to your other apps, like Gmail or Drive, with your own permissions	+ → Connectors; Settings → Customize → Connectors	5.2
Code execution and file creation	Claude runs code on a server to create and edit documents, spreadsheets, presentations and PDFs. Skills and artifacts depend on it	Settings → Capabilities	3.6, 4.3

The exam link

- Task statement 3.1 (Domain 3, Product and Model Selection): "Select appropriate Claude product features (Projects, research mode, chat, artifacts)." This is the Platform Awareness skill from Lesson 0.2: knowing what each tool can and can't do.
- §7, How to Prepare: "Review official Anthropic documentation and help articles for Claude features such as Projects, Artifacts, Memory, Skills, and Code Execution."
- Code is in scope only as escalation awareness: knowing when to hand technical work to a developer.

The lesson's practice scenario (original, not from the exam). A marketing coordinator must compare five competitors' pricing and features by Friday, and her director wants sources he can check. The most appropriate way to use Claude is **B, turn on Research**. A quick chat on the fastest model (A) gives one answer without the sources. The Code tab (C) is for software. A Project built on last year's notes (D) starts from stale information. The Help Center says Research is for comprehensive gathering ("five or more tool calls") and "can do things like compare business competitors", with proper citations. She'd still check those sources.

Quick check

Before you move on, take this lesson's quick check. It's a few short questions and takes a couple of minutes. This lesson completes Section 0, which has no module quiz; Module 1's quiz comes after Lesson 1.4. The exam-style question in this lesson, the quick checks, the

module quizzes and the practice exams are all original, written for this course against the official blueprint. They are never copies of the real exam.

Sources (all checked 2026-10-03)

- **Anthropic blog, *Claude Cowork and chat are now one Claude*** (September 16, 2026): https://claude.com/blog/cowork-is-now-claude
- **Claude Help Center:**
  - *Claude Cowork and chat are one Claude*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/16761823-claude-cowork-and-chat-are-one-claude (the layout test, what stays, what moves)
  - *Get started with Claude Cowork*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/13345190-get-started-with-claude-cowork
  - *Release notes*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/12138966-release-notes
  - *Install Claude Desktop*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/10065433-install-claude-desktop
  - *Get started with Claude*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/8114491-get-started-with-claude
  - *Change the model, effort, and thinking settings*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/8664678-change-the-model-effort-and-thinking-settings
  - *What are projects?*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/9517075-what-are-projects
  - *What are artifacts and how do I use them?*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/17153992-what-are-artifacts-and-how-do-i-use-them
  - *Use research on Claude*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11088861-use-research-on-claude
  - *When should I use web search, extended thinking, and research?*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11095361-when-should-i-use-web-search-extended-thinking-and-research (the exam-angle rationale)
  - *Use Claude's chat search and memory to build on previous context*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11817273-use-claude-s-chat-search-and-memory-to-build-on-previous-context
  - *What are skills?*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/12512176-what-are-skills and *Use skills in Claude*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/12512180-use-skills-in-claude
  - *Use connectors to extend Claude's capabilities*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11176164-use-connectors-to-extend-claude-s-capabilities
  - *Create and edit files with Claude*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/12111783-create-and-edit-files-with-claude
  - *Browse skills, connectors, and plugins in one directory*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/14328846-browse-skills-connectors-and-plugins-in-one-directory

    - *Use incognito chats*: https://support.claude.com/en/articles/12260368-use-incognito-chats
- **Claude Code docs:** *Get started with the desktop app*: https://code.claude.com/docs/en/desktop-quickstart and *Use Claude Code Desktop*: https://code.claude.com/docs/en/desktop
- **Anthropic, *Claude Certified Associate – Foundations Exam Guide*.** Version 1.0, effective July 2026. §6 task 3.1 (p. 5); §7 How to Prepare (p. 6).
- **The app itself:** Claude Desktop 2.9939.4 on Linux, Max plan, observed 2026-10-03. Menus and labels can change between versions.

What you see in the lesson is a real account. The model picker is framed on the Opus, Sonnet and Haiku rows, the models this course and the exam teach. Settings → Account and Settings → Memory were never opened.